

## An Older Autistic Colleague / Fellow Volunteer

**For colleagues, employers & fellow volunteers** — working or volunteering with an **older autistic adult** (roughly 60+).

### The one idea

Autism, through **monotropism**, means an older colleague's attention has always locked into a few deep, intense "tunnels." Many were never identified and bring a lifetime of deep expertise, reliability and honesty to their role — paid or volunteer. The adjustments that help (clarity, predictability, fewer interruptions, written communication, a quieter spot) are the same as for anyone, with extra allowance for hearing or vision changes that can compound lifelong sensory differences.

### What you may see — and what's really going on

| You may see...                                    | What's often happening                                    |
|---------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Deep expertise in one area; prefers defined tasks | Lifelong <b>special interest</b> and focus — a real asset |
| Same routine, same role, every week               | Predictability is <b>regulation</b> , not inflexibility   |
| Slow to answer; asks you to repeat                | Processing time + possible hearing loss — not confusion   |
| Avoids loud meetings, open-plan or socials        | Managing a lifelong sensory/social load                   |
| Takes things literally; misses office banter      | Literal, single-channel communication                     |

### Try this

- **Be clear and predictable** — written briefs, defined tasks, advance notice of changes.
- **Lower the sensory load** — quieter spot, good lighting, fewer interruptions; account for hearing/vision loss.
- **Play to the expertise** — defined, depth-friendly tasks let them shine.
- **Communicate literally and in writing**, with ample processing time.
- **Make social optional and low-pressure** — belonging shouldn't depend on loud events.

### Avoid this

- Surprise changes, loud group demands, or "think fast" pressure.
- Assuming slowness or a different style means decline or incapacity.
- Equating quiet or routine with "not a team player."

### When to get more support

Be alert to **social isolation** and accumulated **burnout** in this group, and to the hard **dementia-or-difference?** question — if you notice a real change in skills, raise it supportively and seek autism-informed assessment rather than assuming. Signpost community and autism-led connection.

## If your colleague is a woman

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Older autistic women are an especially under-identified group, having masked for a lifetime; a history of “anxiety” or lifelong social/sensory difference is worth taking seriously.

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### About this guide

*AI-assisted, derived from this project's research drafts — the **Family guide** (Part 5), the **Lifespan Practitioner & Health-Care guide** (Parts 3.4–3.5) and the **Monotropism** brief. Uses identity-first language. **Informational — not a diagnostic tool**. Old-age evidence is thin; fit it to the individual.*

**Key sources.** Murray, Lesser & Lawson (2005); Murray, F. (2023); Dwyer (2025); Klein et al. (2024, aging & autism); Knight (2021); Booth (2021). Full citations are in the source drafts.